

Assassin's Creed III: Liberation

AS Component 1: Investigating the Media A level Component 1: Media Products, Industries and Audiences

Subject Content: Media Industries Focus Area: Audiences, Media Contexts

PRODUCT CONTEXT

- *Assassin's Creed III: Liberation*, part of the very successful games franchise, was developed by Ubisoft and released on October 30 2012, along with *Assassin's Creed III*.
- The game was originally exclusive to the PS Vita but was later (2014) released in a modified HD version across a large range of consoles and platforms (including PS3, Xbox 360 and Microsoft Windows).
- *Assassin's Creed III: Liberation* offers familiar pleasures to existing fans (narrative situation of the Assassins v the Templars, open world gameplay etc.) along with new elements to target a wider audience (e.g. the use of a strong female protagonist).

PART 1: STARTING POINTS – Media Industries

Historical Contexts:

Video games are a relatively **new media form**. Consider the exponential **growth** of this form since the 1970s, the rapid **technological development**, the construction of “the gamer” and the difficulty of **regulating** or monitoring the impact of such a fast paced industry.

Economic and Political Contexts:

Video games are culturally and financially significant across three major territories (Japan, Europe and the USA). The release of new gaming **technology** (PS Vita is considered part of the 8th generation of game technology) or games from popular franchises can be major **economic events**. It would be useful to explore the way that games and technology (and specifically those from within the *Assassin's*

Creed game **franchise**) have been **marketed** and received across the three major territories.

Consider processes of production, distribution and circulation:

- The game was **released** on the Sony hand held device PlayStation Vita. It was developed by Ubisoft and released alongside *Assassin's Creed III* on the PlayStation 3.
- This **simultaneous release** might be discussed in terms of an attempt to have maximum impact on the three **major markets** for console and video game release (Japan, North America and Europe).
- In terms of **production** the game was a multinational development which is typical of game production in larger studios such as Ubisoft.

Consider the relationship of recent technological change and media production, distribution and circulation:

- The ways in which the PS Vita was attempting to tap into the increasing success of **mobile gaming** (smart phones, tablets etc.). The PS Vita was designed with many features usually associated with smart phones (touchscreen as well as Wi-Fi, 3G and Bluetooth capability).
- The game itself as part of a well-known and popular **franchise** may be seen as an attempt to bring high game **production values** to the burgeoning new mobile gaming arena. It is significant that the game was originally exclusive to the PS Vita but was later (2014) released in a modified HD version across a large range of consoles and **platforms** (including PS3, Xbox 360 and Microsoft Windows).
- In terms of **distribution** these versions of the game could be purchased over the internet using such outlets as Steam, the Playstation Network or Xbox Live Arcade.

Consider the regulatory framework and the role of regulation in global production, distribution and circulation:

- **Video Game regulation** differs around the world but is becoming standardised